As in the past, John Kennedy was relying on his younger brother to maintain a line of communication to Khrushchev. The one that had worked previously, via Dobrynin, was no longer effective: nothing was coming through, despite Robert's reminder to Dobrynin on the evening of November 18 that the president was waiting for a reply. On November 18 Robert went to see his other Soviet contact, the military intelligence officer Georgii Bolshakov. The message was short and clear: Kennedy needed a response from Khrushchev before the start of his press conference at 6:00 p.m. EST on November 20. If the bombers were not removed, low-level reconnaissance flights would resume. As in the past, Robert Kennedy was not bluffing.[3]

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IN MOSCOW, KHRUSHCHEV DECIDED THAT HE COULD NOT wait any longer for Mikoyan to produce a Cuban miracle. Not knowing yet that Castro had already caved on the issue of the bombers, he sent Kennedy a letter accepting his conditions. It was delivered by Dobrynin to Robert Kennedy a few hours before the president went to his press conference.

The two key sentences in the letter—long and rambling, as usual—read: "We expressed our readiness to remove also the IL-28 planes from Cuba. I inform you that we intend to remove them within a month term and maybe even sooner since the term for the removal of these planes is not a matter of principle for us." Khrushchev no longer insisted on an end to overflights or a guarantee that there would be no invasion of Cuba, saving those issues for future negotiations. On the lifting of the blockade, he wrote: "Permit me to express the hope that with receipt of this communication of mine you will issue instructions to the effect that the quarantine be lifted immediately with the withdrawal of your naval and other military units from the Caribbean area."[4]

Unbeknownst to the Americans, Khrushchev's letter to Kennedy included two paragraphs that he had never written or dictated. They were apparently added by Dobrynin on instructions from Moscow or by someone in Moscow after the letter had already been written and cabled to the